

HIGH & MIGHTY *Shoorveer*, where an elite task force comes together for a mission

To ensure authenticity, roping in a military advisor or a defence consultant is now imperative

July, Disney+ Hotstar's *Shoorveer* will see an elite task force consisting of the finest from the army, navy and air force come together for a mission. While some of India's streaming giants have shown men in uniform battle China (Disney+ Hotstar's *1962: The War in the Hills*) and even zombies (Netflix's *Ghoul*), others have chosen to put women in the spotlight (AltBalaji's *The Test Case* and *Code M*).

Despite their profusion, it must be noted that making a defence-based show is not easy. Since wars are never fought with one-man armies, budgets are often steep. Exposed to international programming, audiences want action sequences to be awe-inspiring. "You have to wow the audience with imagery," says Acharya. "Only then does it make for an edge-of-the-seat experience."

After AltBalaji faced legal trouble for its depiction of an army officer in an episode of its series *XXX* (2018), roping in a military advisor or a defence consultant, most often a retired officer, is now imperative. This is why Dice Media had three-star lieutenant general I.S. Singha as an expert to vet the scripts and ensure accuracy when it came to insignia on uniforms, ranks and even the language the anthology employed. The makers of *Avrodh* went a step further and sent their scripts to the Additional Directorate General of Public Information in the defence ministry for clearance.

That's not to say creative liberties cannot be taken. "We use our discretion in a manner that's not damaging to national interest," says Acharya. "You can glamorise within the realm of authenticity. But it cannot be *Rambo*-ish." For the upcoming season of *Avrodh*, the name of the lead protagonist has been changed from Pradeep Arya to Chakravarty and character arcs of the terrorists have also been etched out. "For heroism to stand out, the villains have to also be known," adds Acharya.

According to Aditi Shrivastava, showrunner of *Bravehearts* and co-founder & CEO of Pockets Aces, the appeal lies in expanding the dimensions of the genre by moving the action beyond the border. "We wanted to see what it means to not just be in the army but also to belong to an army family," she says.

In *Bravehearts*, the stories centre on a widow's grief, an officer battling PTSD and a woman trying to get into the army. The ideas, she says, came from a writer's room with many army kids in it.

The genre's popularity is unlikely to wane. The box office success of the recently released *Top Gun: Maverick* is a case in point. Sameer Nair, CEO of Applause Entertainment, which has produced *Avrodh* and the upcoming Hindi adaptation of Israeli show *Fauda* (2015—), believes that India hasn't built up the storytelling impulse of "patriots protecting the homeland" enough. "Americans have built a culture of being proud of the flag, [of protecting] America from all sort of imagined and real dangers," he says. "I think it is important to do that more here." ■

–Suhani Singh

MUSIC

Ready for Battle

Web shows set in the field of war



THE TEST CASE *(2017)*| ALT Balaji/ ZEE5

Are women unsuited for combat roles in the army? Convinced the only answer here is a resounding 'no', Captain Shikha Sharma (Nimrat Kaur) fights many biases in her effort to become a combat officer.



THE FORGOTTEN ARMY: AZAADI KE LIYE *(2020)* Amazon Prime Video

We all know that Netaji led the Azad Hind Fauj during WWII, but little is known about the INA soldiers. This Kabir Khan-directed miniseries aims to fill that crucial gap.



21 SARFAROSH– SARAGRAHI 1897 *(2018)* discovery+

In September 1897, 21 soldiers from the 36th Sikh regiment of the British Indian Army defended an outpost at Saragarhi against an attack by over 10,000 Pashtun and Orakzai warriors. This is their story.